

Q Is it possible to choose where I have my baby?

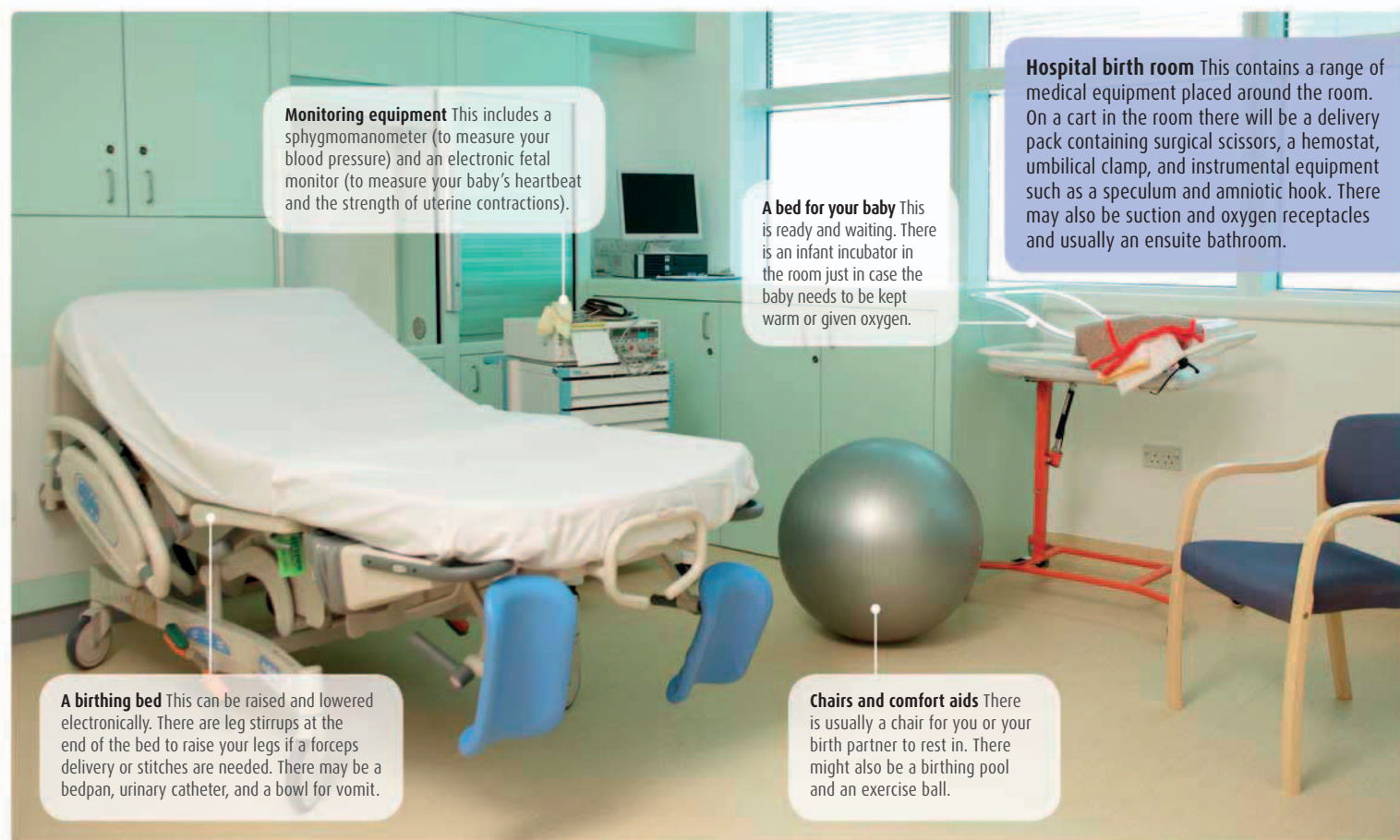
Once you've chosen your health-care provider, there often isn't much choice in the matter, but there may be. The majority of babies born to women in the US are delivered in hospitals by doctors. If you have a doctor, it's very likely that your OB/GYN is affiliated with one or more hospitals in your area. If you've chosen a midwife, you'll likely give birth in a local birth center.

Visit each venue

In order to make an informed decision, it's advisable to take a tour of all the places you can give birth at. When visiting a venue bring a notepad with you to jot down answers to your questions. Don't be afraid to trust your instincts. If you're considering a home birth, meet with your doctor as well to discuss this option. Your midwife will give you a list of what you will need to have for a home birth.

What to ask at every venue

- Who will manage my birth plan?
- How easy is it to park and how far away is the parking?
- If I felt unable to travel once I went into labor, how would you recommend that I get to your location? Is getting a ride from an ambulance a reasonable option?
- Do you have exercise balls, mats, and chairs available in every birthing suite?
- Can I give birth in water?
- How many birth partners can I have?
- Can I bring my other children?
- Can my partner stay with me overnight after the baby has been born?
- How soon will I be able to go home?
- What pain relief will be available to me when I'm in labor?
- Other than my birth partner, who will be in the room with me?
- Will the baby stay with me all the time?
- What help will I have with starting to breast-feed?



Monitoring equipment This includes a sphygmomanometer (to measure your blood pressure) and an electronic fetal monitor (to measure your baby's heartbeat and the strength of uterine contractions).

A bed for your baby This is ready and waiting. There is an infant incubator in the room just in case the baby needs to be kept warm or given oxygen.

Hospital birth room This contains a range of medical equipment placed around the room. On a cart in the room there will be a delivery pack containing surgical scissors, a hemostat, umbilical clamp, and instrumental equipment such as a speculum and amniotic hook. There may also be suction and oxygen receptacles and usually an ensuite bathroom.

A birthing bed This can be raised and lowered electronically. There are leg stirrups at the end of the bed to raise your legs if a forceps delivery or stitches are needed. There may be a bedpan, urinary catheter, and a bowl for vomit.

Chairs and comfort aids There is usually a chair for you or your birth partner to rest in. There might also be a birthing pool and an exercise ball.